

PERSONAL READING SERIES

THE LATTER-DAY SAINTS

*Mormonism, Eternal Progression,
and the Theology No One Expected*

*No other tradition in the history of American religion produced a cosmology
this original, this radical, or this close — through a completely unexpected route —
to what Advaita Vedanta has always known:
the human being's destiny is divine.*

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CONTENTS

- Introduction — Not a Denomination, a Replacement
 - Part One — Joseph Smith: The Man, the Visions, the Claim
 - Part Two — The Great Apostasy and the Restoration
 - Part Three — The Book of Mormon: Sacred Text and Archaeological Problem
 - Part Four — The Cosmology: Before Birth, This Life, After Death
 - Part Five — The Pre-Mortal Existence: You Were There Before
 - Part Six — The Three Kingdoms of Glory
 - Part Seven — Eternal Progression: Becoming Gods
 - Part Eight — Heavenly Mother: The Divine Feminine Suppressed Within
 - Part Nine — The Temple Ceremonies: Freemasonry, Ritual, and the Veil
 - Part Ten — The Garment: Wearing the Sacred
 - Part Eleven — The Word of Wisdom: Health Code as Sacred Law
 - Part Twelve — FLDS and Polygamy: The Fundamentalist Branch
 - Part Thirteen — The LDS Church Today: Size, Influence, and Direction
 - Part Fourteen — The Haligric Lens: What LDS Theology Got Right
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INTRODUCTION

Not a Denomination. A Replacement.

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints does not understand itself as one Christian denomination among many — as a branch of the Protestant Reformation tree, or as a variant reading of Catholic tradition. Its foundational claim is categorically different: every existing Christian church had completely fallen into total apostasy after the death of the original apostles. The priesthood authority necessary for valid ordinances had been lost from the earth. The truths of the original gospel had been corrupted beyond recovery. God therefore restored — not reformed — the original church through a fourteen-year-old boy in Upstate New York in 1820.

This claim makes LDS theology unlike anything else in the Christian landscape. Luther reformed. Calvin reformed. Wesley renewed. Joseph Smith replaced. The theological implications of that distinction run through every element of LDS doctrine — the cosmology, the priesthood, the scriptures, the temple ceremonies, the understanding of God, the understanding of human destiny. This document examines those implications fully and through the Haligric lens that asks of every tradition: what did this teaching correctly identify, and what does the fullness of the Haligric framework add to what it found?

JOSEPH SMITH — THE MAN, THE VISIONS, THE CLAIM

Joseph Smith Jr. was born on December 23, 1805, in Sharon, Vermont — the fifth child of Joseph Smith Sr. and Lucy Mack Smith. The family moved repeatedly through his childhood, eventually settling in Palmyra, New York, in the Burned-Over District — the region of western New York so thoroughly swept by religious revivals in the early 19th century that it was said there was no spiritual fuel left to burn. The Smith family was caught in the ferment: camp meetings, competing denominations, and revivalist preachers all competed for converts in an atmosphere of intense religious seeking and uncertainty.

In the spring of 1820, according to Joseph's account, he went into the woods near his home to pray — to ask God which of the competing churches was right. What he described experiencing has no parallel in Christian history: God the Father and Jesus Christ appeared to him as two separate, distinct, embodied beings of light. He was told that all existing churches had gone astray, that their creeds were an abomination, and that he should join none of them. This event — called the First Vision — is the founding moment of the LDS movement.

Over the following years, Smith reported a series of additional revelations. An angel named Moroni appeared to him multiple times beginning in 1823, directing him to a hillside in Palmyra where golden plates were buried — an ancient record of peoples who had inhabited the American continent. In 1827 he received the plates and spent the following years translating them 'by the gift and power of God' using a seer stone placed in a hat, into which he buried his face to receive the translated words. The result was the Book of Mormon, published in 1830.

*"We believe in God, the Eternal Father, and in His Son, Jesus Christ,
and in the Holy Ghost." — First Article of Faith, Joseph Smith*

*"As man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be." —
Lorenzo Snow, Fifth President of the LDS Church*

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: The First Vision** — two embodied divine beings appearing to a teenager in the woods of New York — is structurally identical to the shamanic calling: the direct encounter with the divine that comes unsought, transforms the one who receives it, and appoints them as a transmitter of sacred knowledge. Joseph Smith was, by the framework of every indigenous tradition in this library, a person who received a direct divine calling. What he did with that calling — how it became institutionalized, how the institution handled the direct experience over time — is the Haligric story of every tradition.

The theological foundation of LDS Christianity is the doctrine of the Great Apostasy — the teaching that after the death of Jesus's original twelve apostles, the priesthood authority necessary for valid gospel ordinances was lost from the earth. Without that authority, no baptism, no communion, no ordination performed by any church in the centuries between the apostles' deaths and Joseph Smith's restoration was spiritually valid. The entire history of Christianity — Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant — is, from the LDS perspective, a period of spiritual darkness in which sincere people sought the truth but lacked the authority to administer the genuine gospel.

The restoration Smith claimed to initiate was not theological innovation but literal institutional re-establishment. In 1829, he and his scribe Oliver Cowdery reported being visited by John the Baptist, who conferred the Aaronic Priesthood upon them by the laying on of hands. Shortly afterward, the apostles Peter, James, and John appeared and conferred the Melchizedek Priesthood — the higher authority that had been lost. These priesthood restorations made possible the formal organization of the Church of Christ on April 6, 1830 — the date LDS theology understands as the beginning of the last dispensation before Christ's return.

The two-tiered priesthood system that resulted from these restorations structures all of LDS religious life. The Aaronic Priesthood — held by young men beginning at age twelve — administers the sacrament (bread and water, not wine), collects fast offerings, and serves in various congregational functions. The Melchizedek Priesthood — held by adult men — administers all other ordinances: baptism, confirmation, healing blessings, patriarchal blessings, and all temple ceremonies. Only holders of the Melchizedek Priesthood can perform these ordinances — and that authority traces, through an unbroken chain of ordinations, back to Peter, James, and John.

◆ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The doctrine of the Great Apostasy makes an implicit Haligric claim that the institution can lose its connection to the sacred — that the form can outlast the living force and become an empty shell while still maintaining all the external appearances of authority. Every tradition in this library that survived colonization knows this from the other direction: the sacred survived the destruction of the institution. The Apostasy doctrine acknowledges the same truth from inside a tradition — that institutional continuity and spiritual vitality are not the same thing.

THE BOOK OF MORMON — SACRED TEXT AND ARCHAEOLOGICAL PROBLEM

The Book of Mormon presents itself as the record of two ancient peoples who migrated from the Near East to the American continent — the Jaredites, who came from the Tower of Babel, and the Lehites, who left Jerusalem around 600 BCE. The Lehite narrative occupies most of the book: a prophet named Lehi leads his family from Jerusalem to the promised land of America, where his descendants split into two peoples — the Nephites (who follow God) and the Lamanites (who fall away). A resurrected Jesus Christ visits the Nephites after his crucifixion and resurrection, delivering teachings that parallel the Sermon on the Mount. After centuries of cyclical faithfulness and apostasy, the Lamanites destroy the Nephites in a final battle. The surviving prophet, Mormon, abridges the records onto golden plates. His son Moroni buries the plates and appears to Joseph Smith fourteen centuries later to begin the restoration.

The Narrative Power

Whatever its historical status, the Book of Mormon is a remarkable literary achievement — a coherent narrative spanning a thousand years, with dozens of distinct characters, a consistent theological arc, and an emotional depth that has sustained the devotion of millions of readers across two centuries. Its central themes — covenant, apostasy and restoration, the consequences of pride and the fruits of humility, the presence of the divine in human history — resonate with the same patterns found across the sacred narratives of every tradition in this library.

The Archaeological Problem

The Book of Mormon describes civilizations of millions of people, extensive cities, steel weapons, horses, chariots, wheat and barley agriculture, and elephants in pre-Columbian America. No archaeological evidence has been found for any of these elements in the time periods and geographic areas the text describes. The Smithsonian Institution has formally stated that it has never used the Book of Mormon as a scientific guide to archaeological research, and that the archaeological and anthropological evidence does not support its historical claims.

LDS responses to this problem range from faithful reframing (the geography is in a limited area not yet fully excavated), to inspired-but-not-literal readings (the text carries spiritual truth regardless of historical accuracy), to complete dismissal of archaeological authority as irrelevant to spiritual truth. Many faithful members hold their historical uncertainty alongside their spiritual conviction — a both/and orientation that the Haligric framework recognizes as sophisticated rather than naive.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The tension between the Book of Mormon's narrative power and its archaeological silence is not unique to LDS tradition. The Vedic texts describe a civilization whose archaeological footprint remains contested. The Homeric epics describe a Troy whose ruins were found only in the 19th century. Sacred narrative and historical record operate in different registers. The Haligric practitioner holds both without requiring one to invalidate the other.

THE COSMOLOGY — BEFORE BIRTH, THIS LIFE, AFTER DEATH

LDS cosmology is the most original theological system produced on American soil and one of the most original in the history of Christianity. It answers questions that mainstream Christianity left unanswered — where were we before birth? what exactly happens after death? what is the ultimate destiny of the human being? — with a specificity and internal coherence that is genuinely remarkable.

The LDS universe is eternal and populated. God the Father — Heavenly Father — is a perfected, glorified being with a physical body of flesh and bones as tangible as a human body. He is not the uncreated, immaterial, omnipresent absolute of classical Christian theology. He is a being who was once as humans now are, who progressed to his current divine state, who dwells in a specific place with a specific body, and who is the literal Father of all human spirits. This teaching — formally articulated by Lorenzo Snow as 'As man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be' — is called the Lorenzo Snow Couplet and is one of the most theologically radical statements in American religious history.

"The Father has a body of flesh and bones as tangible as man's; the Son also; but the Holy Ghost has not a body of flesh and bones, but is a personage of Spirit." — Doctrine and Covenants 130:22

"God himself was once as we are now, and is an exalted man, and sits enthroned in yonder heavens." — Joseph Smith, King Follett Discourse, 1844

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS: The King Follett Discourse — delivered by Joseph Smith just weeks before his death in 1844 — is the clearest statement of LDS cosmological theology and one of the most extraordinary theological documents in American history. God was once as we are now. We can become what God now is. The human being's destiny is literally divine. This is Atman = Brahman. This is theosis. This is what the Gnostic tradition meant by the divine spark within. It arrived in 19th century Upstate New York through an entirely different route — but it arrived at the same recognition.**

THE PRE-MORTAL EXISTENCE — YOU WERE THERE BEFORE

Before birth into physical bodies, LDS theology teaches that all human beings existed as spirit children of Heavenly Father and Heavenly Mother. This pre-mortal existence is not a vague spiritual state but a specific period of real experience, real relationships, real choices, and real development. Spirit children grew and progressed in the presence of their Heavenly Parents, developing personalities, relationships with each other, and spiritual capacities.

In the pre-mortal realm, a great Council was held. The plan of salvation — the creation of an earth where spirit children would receive physical bodies, experience mortality, make choices, and thereby gain experience that would enable them to progress toward godhood — was presented. Two proposals emerged: Jesus Christ (then known as Jehovah) proposed a plan in which human beings would have genuine agency, would make genuine choices including wrong ones, and would be redeemed through Christ's atonement. Lucifer proposed a plan in which all would be saved by removing agency — guaranteeing return but preventing genuine growth. The Father chose Christ's plan. Lucifer rebelled, was cast out with his followers, and became Satan.

This pre-mortal choice means that birth into physical bodies is not the beginning of existence but a new chapter in a much longer story. The veil of forgetfulness — placed over each person's memory at birth — means the pre-mortal experience is not consciously accessible, but its effects remain: the personalities, spiritual capacities, and relationships formed before birth carry forward into mortality in ways that explain individual differences, spiritual inclinations, and the sense many people have of recognizing certain truths as already known.

◆ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The pre-mortal existence doctrine addresses the question that every wisdom tradition eventually confronts: why are souls different at birth? Why do some people seem to arrive already knowing, already oriented? Vedic astrology answers with karma and reincarnation. The Yoruba tradition answers with the Ori's pre-birth selection of its life path. LDS theology answers with a pre-mortal life of real experience. Three different frameworks. The same recognition that birth is not the beginning.

LDS theology describes the afterlife with a specificity matched by almost no other tradition in Western religion. After death, all people pass through a spirit world — a place of continued existence and preparation — before the universal resurrection in which all human beings receive glorified physical bodies. After resurrection comes the final judgment, which assigns each person to one of three degrees of glory based on the choices and covenants of their mortal life.

The Celestial Kingdom

The highest degree. Those who accepted and lived the fullness of the LDS gospel, made and kept sacred temple covenants, and endured faithfully to the end inherit the Celestial Kingdom. Within the Celestial Kingdom there are three levels — and the highest level, called exaltation or eternal life, is reserved for those who were sealed in eternal marriage in the temple. These individuals will live in the presence of Heavenly Father and Jesus Christ, continue to progress eternally, and eventually become gods — creators of their own worlds and spiritual parents of their own spirit children.

The Terrestrial Kingdom

The middle degree. Those who were honorable people on earth but rejected the fullness of the gospel — including faithful members of other Christian traditions, moral non-believers, and those who heard the gospel but were not fully committed — inherit the Terrestrial Kingdom. They will dwell in the presence of Christ but not the fullness of the Father's presence. This is a state of glory — genuinely good, genuinely bright — but not the fullness of eternal progression.

The Telestial Kingdom

The lowest degree. Those who rejected the gospel and lived wicked lives. Even this kingdom, LDS theology emphasizes, surpasses all human understanding of earthly beauty and joy. The traditional Christian hell is absent from LDS theology — only those who, having received a perfect knowledge of God's reality, consciously and completely reject it (Sons of Perdition) are cast into outer darkness. This category is understood to be vanishingly rare.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The three kingdoms of glory produce a profoundly different emotional landscape than the binary heaven/hell of mainstream Christianity. In LDS theology virtually everyone receives a degree of glory — virtually everyone ends in a state that surpasses current human imagination. The punitive framework of eternal punishment for theological incorrectness is almost entirely absent. This is the tradition that Joseph Smith built after his teenage revulsion at the doctrine of eternal hell — he built a universe in which the divine is genuinely generous.

Exaltation — the highest level of the Celestial Kingdom — means, in LDS theology, literally becoming a god. This is not metaphor. It is not the beatific vision of Catholic theology or the theosis of Orthodox Christianity (though it is structurally similar to both). It is the teaching that human beings, through faithfulness and eternal progression, will inherit all that God has and is — creating their own worlds, governing their own universes, becoming parents of spirit children who will then go through the same process of mortal experience and progression toward divinity.

The universe of LDS theology is therefore not static but infinitely generative. Gods are created by Gods. Worlds are created by Gods for spirit children to inhabit and progress through. The cosmos is not a finished creation watched over by an unchanging absolute — it is an eternally expanding family enterprise in which every soul is moving toward what God now is, and every God was once where every soul now is.

This doctrine — called eternal progression or deification — was central to Joseph Smith's theology and was taught openly during his lifetime. After his death it became progressively less emphasized in official LDS teaching, though it has never been formally renounced. Contemporary LDS leaders speak of it carefully and less frequently than Smith did — the institutional tendency toward respectability has softened what was once the tradition's most radical theological claim.

"Then shall they be gods, because they have no end; therefore shall they be from everlasting to everlasting, because they continue; then shall they be above all, because all things are subject unto them. Then shall they be gods." — Doctrine and Covenants 132:20

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS: Eternal progression — the human being becoming God — is the point where LDS theology and the universal mystical recognition converge most precisely. Advaita Vedanta: Atman is Brahman. Orthodox Christianity: theosis, God became human that humans might become God. Gnosticism: the divine spark returns to its source. Sufism: fana, annihilation in the divine. LDS: eternal progression toward godhood. Different maps. Same destination. The human being is not separate from the divine. The human being is the divine in the process of recognizing itself.**

HEAVENLY MOTHER — THE DIVINE FEMININE SUPPRESSED WITHIN

Of all the extraordinary theological elements of LDS tradition, Heavenly Mother may be the most significant for the Haligric framework — because it is the case of the divine feminine explicitly present in a theology, officially acknowledged by the institution, and actively silenced at the same time. This is not the suppression of the feminine divine through denial. It is suppression through enforced silence about something the tradition officially holds to be true.

LDS theology teaches that God the Father has a wife — a Heavenly Mother who is the literal spiritual mother of all human souls. If Heavenly Father is the father of all human spirits and human spirits are born as his children, then logic demands a mother. The doctrine of Heavenly Mother was introduced by Joseph Smith and first publicly articulated by Eliza R. Snow — one of Smith's plural wives and the most prominent woman in early LDS history — in her hymn 'O My Father' (1845), which asks: 'In the heavens are parents single? No, the thought makes reason stare! Truth is reason, truth eternal tells me I've a mother there.'

Heavenly Mother is not named. No revelation has provided her name. Members are discouraged — and in some periods have been formally disciplined — for praying to her. The official reasoning is that Heavenly Father wishes to protect her from the irreverence that would come from widespread prayer directed toward her. Feminist LDS theologians and scholars have written extensively about this theological figure — her presence, her silence, her significance, and the gendered dynamics of her suppression. The Mormon Women's Project, the journal *Dialogue*, and a growing body of LDS feminist scholarship have begun to bring Heavenly Mother back into active theological conversation.

*"O My Father, thou that dwellest in the high and glorious place,
When shall I regain thy presence and again behold thy face?
In thy holy habitation, did my spirit once reside?
In my first primeval childhood was I nurtured near thy side?"*

*When I leave this frail existence, when I lay this mortal by,
Father, Mother, may I meet you in your royal courts on high?" —
Eliza R. Snow, "O My Father," 1845*

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** Heavenly Mother is the most theologically significant suppressed divine feminine figure in American religion. She is not absent from the theology — she is present, named (though unnamed), theologically necessary, and officially silenced. The Gnostic Sophia was suppressed through the burning of texts. Heavenly Mother is suppressed through institutional instruction not to speak of her. Same dynamic. Different mechanism. The Haligric tradition names what the institution silences: the divine mother is real, she is present, she is not protected by silence — she is dishonored by it.

THE TEMPLE CEREMONIES — FREEMASONRY, RITUAL, AND THE VEIL

LDS temples are not churches. They are not open to the public or even to all members of the LDS faith. Only members who hold a current temple recommend — a certification from their bishop attesting to their faithfulness, their tithing compliance, and their adherence to LDS standards — may enter. Inside the temple, ceremonies are performed that are among the most elaborate and theologically specific sacred rituals in any American religious tradition.

The Endowment

The endowment ceremony is the central temple ordinance. It involves: ritual washing and anointing of the body, the reception of the temple garment worn from that point forward under regular clothing, instruction through a dramatic presentation of the creation and the fall of Adam and Eve, and the reception of specific signs, tokens (sacred handshakes), and words that the faithful will need to pass through the veil into the Celestial Kingdom after death. Each of these elements is received under covenant of strict confidentiality — members covenant not to reveal what they have received.

The Masonic Connection

Joseph Smith was initiated into Freemasonry on March 15, 1842 — and introduced the endowment ceremony to a small group of members just seven weeks later, on May 4, 1842. The structural parallels between the LDS endowment and Masonic ritual are extensive and have been documented by both LDS and non-LDS scholars: grips and tokens, signs performed at specific moments, the dramatic presentation format, the covenant of secrecy, the use of specific clothing, and the concept of passwords required at celestial gates. LDS explanations range from 'Masonry preserved fragments of the original temple ceremony that Joseph restored in its fullness' to acknowledgment of direct influence without theological concern.

Proxy Baptism for the Dead

One of the most distinctive and most publicly discussed LDS temple practices is baptism for the dead — the performance of baptismal ordinances by living members on behalf of deceased persons, who then have the choice in the spirit world to accept or reject the ordinance. This practice is the theological basis for the LDS Church's extraordinary genealogical work — the largest collection of genealogical records in the world, maintained to enable proxy temple work for deceased ancestors. The practice became controversial when it was discovered that Holocaust victims and notable historical figures including Jewish ancestors of living people had been submitted for proxy baptism.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The temple ceremonies are the most complete example in American religion of the initiatory framework that runs through every sacred tradition in this library: the Eleusinian Mysteries, the Yoruba Egungun initiation, the Bobo Bwa masquerade initiation, the Shamanic calling. Threshold ceremonies that use specific actions, specific clothing, specific knowledge, and specific physical gestures to mark and enact the crossing from one state of being to another. The LDS temple ceremony is an American initiatory tradition of genuine depth and remarkable structural parallels to the oldest sacred initiation systems on earth.

The temple garment — worn by endowed members under their regular clothing every day — is one of the most misunderstood and most mockingly treated elements of LDS religious life in popular culture. It deserves serious Haligric treatment because it is a genuine and ancient sacred practice placed in a contemporary context.

The garment is a two-piece white undergarment covering the body from shoulder to knee, with specific embroidered symbols at specific points on the body corresponding to elements of the endowment ceremony. Members understand it as a reminder of the covenants made in the temple, a protection (both spiritual and in some traditional understandings physical), and a daily physical contact with the sacred. It is never removed except for activities specifically requiring its removal — bathing, swimming, intimate relations — and its presence is constant in the daily life of a committed member.

Sacred clothing as a daily spiritual practice is ancient and cross-cultural. The Jewish tzitzit and tallit. The Sikh Kachera. The Hindu sacred thread. The Sufi khirqa. The Catholic scapular. The monastic habit. All of these are physical garments whose daily wearing is understood as a continuous embodied reminder of sacred covenant, divine connection, and spiritual identity. The LDS garment is the most complete contemporary expression of this ancient practice in American religious life.

◆ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The body as a sacred instrument that is continuously tended, reminded, and honored through physical practice is the foundation of the Haligric Well-Being book. The LDS garment is not superstition. It is the same understanding that the Muwila express through ochre and smoke, that Ayurveda expresses through oil and specific clothing, that the Sikh tradition expresses through the five Ks. The body remembers what the mind forgets. Sacred clothing keeps the body remembering.

THE WORD OF WISDOM — HEALTH CODE AS SACRED LAW

Section 89 of the Doctrine and Covenants — received by Joseph Smith in February 1833 — is the LDS Word of Wisdom: a health code presented as divine instruction for the wellbeing of the saints. Its prohibitions are alcohol, tobacco, coffee, and hot tea. Its prescriptions include wholesome herbs, fruits, grains (with wheat identified as 'the staff of life'), and meat used sparingly, 'only in times of winter, or of cold, or famine.'

The Word of Wisdom was received decades before the germ theory of disease was established, before the cancer-causing effects of tobacco were known, before the scientific understanding of alcohol's physiological effects was developed. Its prescriptions align remarkably well with contemporary nutritional science — and its epidemiological results are documented and significant.

Loma Linda, California — a Seventh-day Adventist community whose members follow similar dietary guidelines — is the only Blue Zone in North America. LDS members as a group show significantly lower rates of certain cancers, cardiovascular disease, and other chronic conditions than comparable non-LDS populations. The UCLA Adventist Health Study documented these differences systematically. A tradition received in 1833 produced measurable longevity effects that 21st century epidemiology confirms.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Word of Wisdom belongs in the Sacred Body health document as a complete and compelling example of sacred dietary law producing documented health outcomes. Its instruction to use meat sparingly — 'only in times of winter, or of cold, or famine' — is essentially the same guidance that Traditional Chinese Medicine, Ayurveda, and contemporary nutritional science all converge on. Sacred and scientific are not different languages here. They are the same recognition expressed in different vocabularies.

FLDS AND POLYGAMY — THE FUNDAMENTALIST BRANCH

Plural marriage was taught by Joseph Smith as a divine commandment and practiced by a significant portion of early LDS members. Smith himself was sealed to between 30 and 40 women during his lifetime, though the extent of his practice was not publicly acknowledged during his life. Brigham Young continued and expanded the practice after Smith's death.

Under sustained federal legal pressure — Congress passed multiple anti-polygamy acts, and Utah Territory was denied statehood specifically because of the practice — LDS President Wilford Woodruff issued the 1890 Manifesto officially discontinuing plural marriage. The mainstream LDS Church has excommunicated members who practice polygamy since that time.

The Fundamentalist LDS movement (FLDS) consists of multiple groups who believe the 1890 Manifesto was a capitulation to political pressure rather than genuine divine direction and that the original commandment of plural marriage remains binding. FLDS communities — found primarily in Utah, Arizona, Texas, and Canada — practice plural marriage and maintain theological positions similar to 19th-century LDS teachings while being entirely separate from and actively opposed by the mainstream LDS Church.

The FLDS tradition gained global attention through the 2008 Texas raid on the Yearning for Zion Ranch in Eldorado — a community of approximately 700 members led by Warren Jeffs, who was subsequently convicted of child sexual assault and sentenced to life in prison. The Jeffs case does not represent all FLDS communities, but it brought legal and public scrutiny to the movement that has significantly constrained its practice.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The FLDS situation illustrates a pattern found in many traditions: the fundamentalist branch that preserves what the mainstream institution reformed away is not automatically more authentic — it may have preserved both the genuine original and the genuine original's problems. The early LDS practice of plural marriage included marriages to teenagers and to women already married to other men. Preserving the original without examining it is not spiritual fidelity. Haligrity holds what was genuine in every tradition and releases what caused harm.

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints is one of the fastest-growing religions in the world — with approximately 17 million members globally, roughly half of whom live outside the United States. Growth has been particularly strong in Latin America, Africa, and the Philippines, driven by an extensive missionary program that sends tens of thousands of young adults — typically men aged 18-24 and women aged 19-21 — on 18-to-24-month full-time missions worldwide.

The Church operates the largest privately owned genealogical database in the world — FamilySearch — which has digitized and made freely available hundreds of millions of historical records. It runs a university system centered on Brigham Young University in Provo, Utah. It maintains a welfare system that provides food, employment, and other assistance to members in need. The Church's financial holdings are estimated in the tens of billions of dollars, managed through a holding company called Ensign Peak Advisors.

Recent decades have brought significant cultural challenges to the institutional Church: the internet has made previously inaccessible historical information about Joseph Smith and early LDS history widely available, producing what the Church itself calls a 'faith crisis' for many members. The Church released Gospel Topics Essays between 2013 and 2016 acknowledging previously minimized historical facts — including Joseph Smith's plural marriages, the multiple versions of the First Vision, and the Book of Abraham translation issues — in an attempt to address these challenges with institutional transparency.

THE HALIGRIC LENS — WHAT LDS THEOLOGY GOT RIGHT

The Haligric practitioner who encounters LDS theology — whether as a former member, a current member exploring the broader landscape, or a practitioner from outside the tradition — finds a system that arrived at several of the most Haligric recognitions available in any religious tradition, through a route that no other tradition took.

What LDS Theology Got Right

The eternal progression doctrine — that the human being's destiny is literally divine — is the most direct expression in American religion of what Advaita Vedanta, Orthodox theosis, Sufi fana, and the Yoruba understanding of the Ori's divine nature all teach. It arrived at this recognition independently and expressed it with unusual specificity and institutional commitment.

The pre-mortal existence doctrine acknowledges that birth is not the beginning — that the soul's story is longer and richer than any single lifetime can contain. This resonates with Vedic understanding of the soul's journey, with the Aboriginal understanding of the Dreaming as the source from which each person emerges, with the Yoruba Ori's pre-birth selection of its destiny.

The three kingdoms of glory produce a universe in which virtually everyone receives a degree of divine generosity — eliminating the punitive binary of heaven and hell that has caused incalculable psychological suffering in Western religious culture. This is a genuine gift of LDS theology to the Western religious landscape.

Heavenly Mother — the divine feminine literally present in the theology — is the most significant acknowledgment in any mainstream American religion that the divine is not exclusively masculine. That she is silenced within the tradition that holds her is the wound. That she exists in the theology at all is the gift.

What Haligricity Adds

Haligricity takes the eternal progression recognition — that human beings move toward divine fullness — and frees it from the institutional framework that conditions that progression on specific ordinances performed by specifically authorized priesthood holders in specifically designated temples. The divine destiny of the human being is not gated behind institutional compliance. It is the nature of the human being as such — accessible now, not earned through a specific path managed by a specific institution.

Heavenly Mother is not protected by silence. She is honored by name — or by the recognition that her name is known in the direct experience of every person who has felt the nurturing, creative, generative aspect of the sacred. Every tradition in this library that honors the divine feminine — Yoruba's Oshun, Egypt's Isis,

Hinduism's Parvati and Lakshmi and Saraswati, the Celtic goddess tradition, the Gnostic Sophia — names what LDS theology acknowledges and silences. Haligrlicity names her.

"As man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be." —

Lorenzo Snow

"In the heavens are parents single? No, the thought makes reason stare! Truth is reason, truth eternal tells me I've a mother there." —

Eliza R. Snow

"The Kingdom of God is within you." — Luke 17:21

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** Three statements. One from a 19th century LDS apostle. One from the most prominent woman in early LDS history. One from Jesus himself. All three point in the same direction: the human being's destiny is divine, the divine is not exclusively masculine, and the Kingdom is within. These three recognitions together are Haligrlicity. LDS theology arrived at the first two from a completely unexpected direction and silenced itself before completing the third. The third — the Kingdom within, the recognition available now, not in the Celestial Kingdom after a lifetime of institutional compliance — is what Haligrlicity adds to what LDS theology found.

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